

contest," the 64-year-old remembers.

Between its first-ever Test against the West Indies in 1976 and its latest international red-ball fixture against Australia in December 2023, India has played 40 Tests, winning seven, losing six, and drawing 27. With the advent of the T20 format in the women's ecosystem in 2004, the frequency of Tests dwindled. Between 1976 and 2004, India played 30 Tests, while from 2005 onwards, only 10 matches have been played.

"It's certainly not the growth format, is it?" former Australian captain Lisa Sthalekar, who has been tracking the scores of the tournament on the BCCI app from Australia, tells Sportstar.

"If we're going to conquer the world, it is through T20 cricket. We're already seeing Thailand and Papua New Guinea forge their way into the fold. Thailand even made it to an ICC event in 2020. You want to see more countries do that. That's where the majority of the funding goes, and perhaps rightly so. But that doesn't mean Test cricket shouldn't exist in the women's ecosystem. It does limit who is involved, but I think that's okay as well. We can't have everything."

Red-ball's geographics

Women's Test cricket is currently dominated by Australia, England, and India, with South Africa starting to follow suit. Other nations, including old-world powers like New Zealand, have been parched for red-ball action. Even if one wants to add a few Tests to the schedule, it's hard to find a window that does not have bilateral white-ball fixtures, franchise short-format tournaments like the Women's Premier League, The Hundred, the Women's Big Bash League, or ICC-recognised private initiatives like FairBreak Global.

"At the moment, the calendar for women's cricket has come a long way from teams having just one or two major series a year at best. If we want more and more Test cricket, where are we slotting it in considering white-ball being the priority and varying economic capabilities to stage the longer format? Even in the men's game, some countries go at a

loss when they put on Test cricket. If you ask Ireland, they might feel differently about Test status now. We need to acknowledge that. But if there are countries that want to play Tests, then absolutely (fine). The players—all of them want to play Test cricket. Maybe we need to do an ICC World XI against whoever is successful among India, England, and Australia so it allows someone like Suzie Bates to play a Test match," Sthalekar says.

India revived the Inter-Zonal tournament for women's multi-day cricket, enhancing its domestic foundation for Test cricket. Unlike England's men's County system, their women lack an equivalent. Australia now hosts a permanent three-day match between 'Green' and 'Gold'

teams annually. New Zealand's Hallyburton Johnstone Shield shifted from multi-day to 50-over format since the late 1990s.

Red is right

World Cup-winning former England skipper Charlotte Edwards, who now coaches a range of domestic outfits across England and Mumbai Indians in the WPL, believes a lack of red-ball experience cost England in the one-off Test against India last December.

"In the Test match, we've seen that if your technique is not strong, you'll get found out. Playing too much white-ball cricket can be detrimental to Tests and we need to find the right balance or even education through playing age-group red-ball cricket," Edwards tells Sportstar.

